2-25

Prez 1

Presenter: Sandy Urazayev
Presentation Name: The Death of the Art of Comptuer Science
Date and time: 2/25 12:00PM

Summary

Sandy, is currently an engineer at an AI startup and is a former Microsoft employee. He gave 2 different perspectives on the current state of artificial intelligence that balance the realistic state of AI with philosophical concern. He began the speech by acknowledging the undeniable impact of AI. He claims it is the most influential and disruptive technology the industry has ever adopted. Sandy openly admits that he has never been more productive; tools like GitHub Copilot allow him to complete complex corporate tasks in minutes rather than days. He argues that AI has effectively commoditized the act of writing code, admitting that it is impossible for engineers like himself to return to manual workflows without a devastating drop in speed. However, he goes more in depth into the "dark side" of the AI revolution (something I feel other presenters did not do enough of) by mention how expensive the hardware is, how bad data centers are for the environment, and the ethical concerns surrounding data "stealing" and systemic biases.

The main point of Sandy's talk is the distinction between programming as an art and software engineering as a business solution. He claims that while software engineering is about solving corporate problems as cheaply and quickly as possible, a goal AI achieves perfectly, the "art" of programming is being lost. By allowing AI to handle the journey of problem-solving, engineers are stripped of the struggle and growth that define their professional development and what makes them human. Sandy warns that the industry is currently in a "race to the bottom", where the demand for hyper-productivity is squeezing junior pipelines and eroding the traditional "craft" of coding. Ultimately, he encourages the audience to use AI as a necessary tool for survival in a brutal corporate landscape but to consciously preserve their own intellectual growth through personal, non-commercial projects. He explains the Roman concept of otium, leisure dedicated to meaningful, human pursuits, and how it is a necessary counterweight to a world increasingly optimized for algorithmic output.

What I learnt

From Sandy's talk, I gained much needed insight on the "productivity trap" of the modern engineer. While I've seen the hype around AI, hearing from someone at the industry's front lines made me realize that while my efficiency might skyrocket, it comes at a cost to my personal growth. I learned that there is a fundamental tension between software engineering (a commoditized business service being optimized by AI) and the art of programming. Sandy taught me that if I rely solely on AI to solve problems, I am essentially "outsourcing" the struggle that actually builds my expertise and humanity. This resonated deeply with me; it's a reminder that to stay a productive engineer without losing my soul, I must intentionally find space for non-commercial projects where I don't use AI. This will help me preserve the knowledge and joy of pure problem-solving. I now understand that I need to be a cautious user of these tools to survive the corporate "race to the bottom" while still guarding my intellectual curiosity.

What I will do diff

After hearing Sandy, I will change how I approach my daily coding workflow. I'll stop viewing AI as a "shortcut" and start treating it as a corporate utility, strictly separating my professional output from my personal growth. To prevent my skills from atrophying, I will commit to "blackout hours" where I solve complex problems manually, ensuring I maintain the muscle memory AI tries to replace. I'll no longer measure my worth solely by speed or volume; instead, I'll prioritize the "art" of my craft in side projects to ensure I don't lose my humanity to the machine.

Prez 2

Presenter: Valter Herman
Presentation Name: None
Date and time: 2/25 12:30PM ish

Summary

Valter is a veteran engineer who graduated in 1998. His presentation a career-oriented guide for students entering a job market that is extremely volatile due to AI and other factors. He is an experienced engineer who has been through the dot-com era. With the rise of big data and AI, he emphasizes that while technical skills are the baseline, "soft skills" and personal branding are the primary drivers of long-term success. He introduces the concept of a "walk-in deck", a short, visual presentation that candidates should use during interviews to tell their personal story and showcase their achievements. Valter argues that in a professional world increasingly influenced by AI, the ability to orchestrate people and build genuine relationships is more valuable than ever. He highlights that people, not just algorithms, determine an individual's career trajectory, happiness, and promotion opportunities.

A significant portion of Valter's talk focuses on the "growth mindset" adopted by Microsoft under Satya Nadella. He encourages students to be "learn-it-alls" rather than "know-it-alls," stressing that the expiration date on technical knowledge is shorter than ever. He notes that while AI can generate content, critical thinking remains a human prerequisite for applying that content to solve real-world business problems. Valter also provides blunt advice on corporate survival, stating that one's immediate manager is the most critical factor in their professional life; a loyal boss who fights for their team is essential for advancement. Regarding the current hiring crisis, he advises students to treat the job search like a sales funnel. Rather than simply submitting resumes into automated systems that are likely to filter them out, candidates must leverage LinkedIn and personal networks to find "warm" referrals. He concludes by urging the audience to invest in themselves and their physical and mental well-being, as these are the only assets that remain stable regardless of economic or technological shifts.

What I learnt

To be honest, Valter's speech was the same as many of the engineers we have seen so far. Still though, I was reminded that in an era where AI can generate code in seconds, my personal brand and network are my most resilient assets. His advice to treat the job search as a "sales funnel" was a wake-up call; I realized that simply polishing my resume isn't enough when automated filters are designed to thin the herd. Instead, I need to be assertive in building a "walk-in deck" and leveraging "warm" referrals to bypass the algorithms.

One new thing I learnt is how my immediate manager will be the single most important factor in my career success, which changed how I plan to evaluate potential employers. I also took away the importance of the "growth mindset"—the idea that I should always be the one asking questions rather than pretending to have all the answers. Ultimately, I learned that while technology changes at an exponential rate, the human elements of trust, orchestration, and relationship-building remain the true keys to a lasting career.

What I will do diff

Following Valter’s advice, I will shift my energy from perfecting my GitHub to perfecting my pitch. I’m going to build a personalized "walk-in deck" immediately to humanize my technical experience during interviews. I’ll stop "shouting into the void" of application portals and instead treat my job search like a sales operation, aggressively leveraging LinkedIn to find direct human connections. Most importantly, I will be more selective about my future leadership; I’ll interview my prospective managers as much as they interview me, ensuring I work for someone who will actively evangelize for my career growth and success.